

Physics of Complex Systems Homework 9

Jun Wei Tan*

Julius-Maximilians-Universität Würzburg

(Dated: June 20, 2026)

Problem 1 (Density Matrix of a Single Qubit). For a given ensemble of qubits the observables

$$A = \begin{pmatrix} 3 & 0 \\ 0 & 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad B = \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & -1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad C = \begin{pmatrix} 0 & 2i \\ -2i & 0 \end{pmatrix},$$

have been measured many times, giving the expectation values

$$\langle A \rangle = 2, \quad \langle B \rangle = \frac{1}{2}, \quad \langle C \rangle = 0.$$

- (a) Determine the density matrix of the ensemble.
- (b) Is the ensemble pure or mixed?
- (c) If we measure σ^z , what is the probability to get +1?
- (d) Determine the expectation values

$$\langle \sigma^x \rangle, \quad \langle \sigma^y \rangle, \quad \langle \sigma^z \rangle.$$

Proof. (a) Given a density matrix ρ , the expectation value of an operator $\mathbf{A}$ is given by $\langle \mathbf{A} \rangle = \text{Tr}(\rho \mathbf{A})$. We implement the trace 1 and hermiticity conditions by defining our density matrix using

$$\rho = \begin{pmatrix} a & b \\ b^* & 1-a \end{pmatrix}.$$

Substituting this in, we find

$$\langle \mathbf{A} \rangle = 1 + 2a = 2$$

$$\langle \mathbf{B} \rangle = -1 + 2a + b + b^* = \frac{1}{2}$$

* jun-wei.tan@stud-mail.uni-wuerzburg.de

$$\langle \mathbf{C} \rangle = -2ib + 2ib^* = 0$$

From the third equation, we see that $b = b^*$, i.e. b is real. From the first equation, we can see easily that $a = \frac{1}{2}$. Substituting this in to the second equation, we find that $2b = \frac{1}{2}$, or $b = \frac{1}{4}$.

(b) We do this using the trace criterion: We have

$$\rho^2 = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{5}{16} & \frac{1}{4} \\ \frac{1}{4} & \frac{5}{16} \end{pmatrix}.$$

Thus, the trace is

$$\text{Tr}(\rho^2) = \frac{10}{16} \neq 1.$$

The ensemble is mixed.

(c) ..

(d) We compute

$$\rho\sigma^z = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{1}{2} & -\frac{1}{4} \\ \frac{1}{4} & -\frac{1}{2} \end{pmatrix}.$$

Thus, we have

$$\langle \rho\sigma^z \rangle = 0.$$

Similarly, we have

$$\rho\sigma^x = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{1}{4} & \frac{1}{2} \\ \frac{1}{2} & \frac{1}{4} \end{pmatrix}$$

with

$$\langle \rho\sigma^x \rangle = \frac{1}{2}$$

and

$$\rho\sigma^y = \begin{pmatrix} \frac{i}{4} & -\frac{i}{2} \\ \frac{i}{2} & -\frac{i}{4} \end{pmatrix}$$

with

$$\langle \rho\sigma^y \rangle = 0.$$

□

Problem 2 (Criterion for the Equivalence of Ensembles). Consider a statistical ensemble $\{|\psi_i\rangle, p_i\}$ with the associated density matrix

$$\rho = \sum_{i=1}^N p_i |\psi_i\rangle \langle \psi_i|.$$

Here N is arbitrary (smaller or larger than the dimension of the Hilbert space) and the vectors $|\psi_i\rangle$ are pairwise different and normalized but not necessarily orthogonal. Moreover, let

$$\rho = \sum_{k=1}^K \lambda_k |k\rangle \langle k|$$

be the spectral decomposition of ρ with orthonormal eigenvectors $|k\rangle$ and eigenvalues λ_k .

The aim of this exercise is to work out an equivalence theorem for different ensembles with the same density matrix.

- (a) Show that every vector $|\psi_i\rangle$ can be written as a linear combination of the eigenvectors $|k\rangle$, i.e.

$$|\psi_i\rangle \in \text{span}\{|k\rangle\}.$$

- (b) Use (a) to prove that every $|\psi_i\rangle$ can be written as

$$\sqrt{p_i} |\psi_i\rangle = \sum_{k=1}^K c_{ik} \sqrt{\lambda_k} |k\rangle,$$

with coefficients c_{ik} obeying

$$\sum_{i=1}^N c_{ik} c_{il}^* = \delta_{kl}, \quad k, l = 1, \dots, K.$$

- (c) Because of (a) we know that $N \geq K$. For $N = K$ the result of (b) would imply that the coefficient matrix c_{ik} is unitary. Show that for $N > K$ the rectangular matrix c_{ik} can be extended to a square unitary matrix such that the relation in (b) still holds.
- (d) So far we have proven that if

$$\sum_{i=1}^N p_i |\psi_i\rangle \langle \psi_i| = \sum_{k=1}^K \lambda_k |k\rangle \langle k|,$$

then there exists a unitary $N \times N$ matrix c_{ik} such that

$$\sqrt{p_i} |\psi_i\rangle = \sum_{k=1}^N c_{ik} \sqrt{\lambda_k} |k\rangle.$$

Prove the converse statement.

(e) Use (a)–(d) to show that

$$p_i = \sum_{k=1}^N T_{ik} \lambda_k,$$

(or in vector form $\vec{p} = T\vec{\lambda}$), where T is a doubly-stochastic matrix, i.e. all matrix entries are real and nonnegative and

$$\sum_{i=1}^N T_{ik} = \sum_{k=1}^N T_{ik} = 1.$$

(f) Use e.g. Mathematica to work out the explicit example

$$p_1 = p_2 = \frac{1}{2}, \quad |\psi_1\rangle = \frac{1}{\sqrt{2}} \begin{pmatrix} 1 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}, \quad |\psi_2\rangle = \begin{pmatrix} 0 \\ 1 \end{pmatrix},$$

with $N = K = 2$, and determine $\lambda_{1,2}$, $|\phi_{1,2}\rangle$, c_{ij} , and T_{ij} . Check the properties derived in (e).

Proof. **Brief note on interpretation:** In the sum

$$\rho = \sum_{k=1}^K \lambda_k |k\rangle\langle k|$$

the sum only contains the eigenvectors with **nonzero** eigenvalue. This is in contrast to the standard way the spectral theorem is written including the kernel. Otherwise, (a) would follow trivially from the spectral theorem, because the vectors $|k\rangle$ would span the space, and the opening statement in (c) would be false, because K would be the dimension of the Hilbert space, and it is not necessarily true that $N \geq \dim \mathcal{H}$.

(a) As from the comment, in this problem we basically seek to show that $|\psi_i\rangle$ is spanned by the eigenvectors with nonzero eigenvalue. However, we also know that the eigenvectors with nonzero eigenvalue span the kernel. Thus, we decompose

$$\mathcal{H} = \ker \rho \oplus \text{im } \rho = \ker \rho \oplus (\ker \rho)^\perp.$$

We seek to show that $|\psi_i\rangle \in \text{im } \rho$. Since this is an orthogonal decomposition, it suffices to show that $\langle \phi | \psi_i \rangle = 0$ for all $|\phi\rangle \in \ker \rho$, i.e. $|\psi_i\rangle$ is orthogonal to $\ker \rho$.

Consider $|\phi\rangle \in \ker \rho$. Then we have

$$0 = \langle \phi | \rho | \phi \rangle = \sum_{i=1}^N p_i \langle \phi | \psi_i \rangle \langle \psi_i | \phi \rangle = \sum_{i=1}^N p_i |\langle \phi | \psi_i \rangle|^2.$$

Since the terms in parentheses are all positive, it follows that $\langle \phi | \psi_i \rangle = 0$ for all $|\psi_i\rangle$. Since $|\phi\rangle$ was arbitrary, the conclusion follows.

(b) Since $|\psi_i\rangle$ is in the span of $|k\rangle$, by definition

$$|\psi_i\rangle = \sum_{k=1}^n a_{ik} |k\rangle.$$

By redefining the coefficients $a_{ik} = c_{ik} \sqrt{\lambda_k} / \sqrt{p_i}$, we can write

$$\sqrt{p_i} |\psi_i\rangle = \sum_{k=1}^K c_{ik} \sqrt{\lambda_k} |k\rangle.$$

Note that we require that $p_i \neq 0$, but this is given. Thus we need to solve the second part. First, we take the conjugate to obtain

$$\sqrt{p_i} \langle \psi_i | = \sum_{k=1}^K c_{ik}^* \sqrt{\lambda_k} \langle k |.$$

We substitute these in the expression from ρ to get

$$\begin{aligned} \rho &= \sum_{i=1}^N p_i |\psi_i\rangle \langle \psi_i| \\ &= \sum_{i=1}^N p_i \left[\frac{1}{\sqrt{p_i}} \sum_{k=1}^K c_{ik} \sqrt{\lambda_k} |k\rangle \right] \left[\frac{1}{\sqrt{p_i}} \sum_{l=1}^K c_{il}^* \sqrt{\lambda_l} \langle l| \right] \\ &= \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{k=1}^K \sum_{l=1}^K c_{ik} c_{il}^* \sqrt{\lambda_k \lambda_l} |k\rangle \langle l| \end{aligned}$$

Now, since the $|k\rangle$ are orthogonal by the spectral theorem, we are allowed to compare coefficients. The off diagonal terms must vanish and we have

$$\sum_{i=1}^N c_{ik} c_{il}^* = \delta_{kl}$$

to obtain the density matrix.

(c) Note on the indices in c_{ik} : i goes from 1 to N and k goes from 1 to $K < N$. Thus, for each k , we have a vector in $\mathbb{C}^N$. The c s are orthonormal for different i . By the basis extension theorem, we can extend this basis to an orthonormal basis of $\mathbb{C}^N$, i.e. pick c_{ik} for $k > K$ such that c_{iks} are orthonormal.

(d) We simply substitute the second equation into the first

$$\begin{aligned}
 \sum_{i=1}^N p_i |\psi_i\rangle\langle\psi_i| &= \sum_{i=1}^N (\sqrt{p_i} |\psi_i\rangle)(\langle\psi_i| \sqrt{p_i}) \\
 &= \sum_{i=1}^N \left[\sum_{k=1}^N c_{ik} \sqrt{\lambda_k} |k\rangle \right] \left[\sum_{l=1}^N c_{il}^* \sqrt{\lambda_l} \langle l| \right] \\
 &= \sum_{k=1}^N \sum_{l=1}^N \underbrace{\left[\sum_{i=1}^N c_{ik} c_{il}^* \right]}_{\delta_{kl}} \sqrt{\lambda_k \lambda_l} |k\rangle\langle l| \\
 &= \sum_{k=1}^N \lambda_k |k\rangle\langle k|
 \end{aligned}$$

(e) We take norms of the equation

$$\sqrt{p_i} |\psi_i\rangle = \sum_{k=1}^n c_{ik} \sqrt{\lambda_k} |k\rangle$$

to get

$$p_i = \sum_{k=1}^N |c_{ik}|^2 \lambda_k.$$

By inspection, we find

$$T_{ik} = |c_{ik}|^2.$$

Clearly, all matrix entries are real and nonnegative. Now, we evaluate the sums

$$\begin{aligned}
 \sum_{k=1}^N T_{ik} &= \sum_{k=1}^N |c_{ik}|^2 \\
 &= \sum_{k=1}^N c_{ik} c_{ik}^* \\
 &= \sum_{k=1}^N c_{ki}^\dagger c_{ik} \\
 &= \delta_{kk} = 1
 \end{aligned}$$

The other sum follows basically identically:

$$\begin{aligned}
 \sum_{i=1}^N T_{ik} &= \sum_{i=1}^N |c_{ik}|^2 \\
 &= \sum_{i=1}^N c_{ik} c_{ik}^* \\
 &= \sum_{i=1}^N c_{ki}^\dagger c_{ik} \\
 &= \delta_{kk} = 1
 \end{aligned}$$

(f) We compute these in Mathematica. First, we directly compute

```
In[1]:= p1 = 1/2;
```

```
In[2]:= p2 = 1/2;
```

```
In[3]:= ψ1 = {1, 1}/√2;
```

```
In[4]:= ψ2 = {0, 1};
```

```
In[5]:= ρ = p1 KroneckerProduct[ψ1, ψ1] + p2 KroneckerProduct[ψ2, ψ2]
```

```
Out[5]= {{1/4, 1/4}, {1/4, 3/4}}
```

to find

$$\begin{aligned}
 \rho &= p_1 |\psi_1\rangle\langle\psi_1| + p_2 |\psi_2\rangle\langle\psi_2| \\
 &= \begin{pmatrix} \frac{1}{4} & \frac{1}{4} \\ \frac{1}{4} & \frac{3}{4} \end{pmatrix}
 \end{aligned}$$

Then, we compute the eigenvalues and eigenvectors using

```
In[6]:= {eigvals, eigvecs} = Eigensystem[ρ]
```

```
Out[6]= {{1/4 (2 + Sqrt[2]), 1/4 (2 - Sqrt[2])}, {{-1 + Sqrt[2], 1}, {-1 - Sqrt[2], 1}}}
```

leading to eigenvalues

$$\lambda_{\pm} = \frac{1}{4}(2 \pm \sqrt{2})$$

and associated eigenvectors

$$|\phi_{\pm}\rangle = \begin{pmatrix} -1 \mp \sqrt{2} \\ 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

Although these vectors are orthogonal, they are not normalised. Thus, we divide through

```
In[7]:= eivcsnorm = #/Norm[#] & /@ eigvecs
```

```
Out[7]= {{(-1 + Sqrt[2])/Sqrt[1 + (-1 + Sqrt[2])^2], 1/Sqrt[1 + (-1 + Sqrt[2])^2]}, {(-1 - Sqrt[2])/Sqrt[1 + (-1 - Sqrt[2])^2], 1/Sqrt[1 + (-1 - Sqrt[2])^2]}}
```

To compute the c_{ik} , we note that the $|k\rangle$ form an orthonormal basis by the spectral theorem. Thus, we have

$$\sqrt{p_i} \langle l | \psi_i \rangle = c_{il} \sqrt{\lambda_l}.$$

Thus, we compute

$$c_{ik} = \frac{\sqrt{p_i} \langle k | \psi_i \rangle}{\sqrt{\lambda_k}}.$$

Defining $|\phi_1\rangle = |\phi_+\rangle = |1\rangle$ and $|\phi_2\rangle = |\phi_-\rangle = |2\rangle$, we thus evaluate these using

```
In[8]:= c = FullSimplify[Table[(Sqrt[p[[i]]] Conjugate[eivcsnorm[[k]]] . psi[[i]])/Sqrt[eigvals[[k]]], {i, 1, 2}, {k, 1, 2}]]
```

```
Out[8]= {{1/Sqrt[2], -1/Sqrt[2]}, {1/Sqrt[2], 1/Sqrt[2]}}
```

The T matrix then follows easily, from $T = |c|^2$ elementwise as

$$T = \frac{1}{2} \begin{pmatrix} 1 & 1 \\ 1 & 1 \end{pmatrix}.$$

□